

ARG

Argument Structure

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Argument structure is how you organize your position so that your listener can follow your reasoning from beginning to end. At ILR 3, a strong argument does three things: it states a clear point, it supports that point with analytical reasoning, and it lifts the argument to a broader universal implication. The PSU arc — Point, Support, Universal — is not a rigid template. It is a way of ensuring that your response moves forward, not just sideways. A response that restates or lists without developing is not yet an argument at ILR 3.

THE PSU ARC — WHAT TO TRY

- P — State your position clearly and directly at the outset. Do not build up to it.
- S — Support your position with analytical reasoning: trace a cause, project a consequence, identify a mechanism, map a stakeholder impact, or evaluate a constraint. Illustration alone is not support at ILR 3.
- U — Lift your argument to a broader implication: what does this mean at a societal, systemic, or universal level? This is the move that separates analysis from opinion.
- Distribute your reasoning across the response — do not front-load everything and trail off.
- Return to your point at the end with new depth, not simple restatement.

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "My position is that... and the reason I hold this view is..."
- "The core issue here is not X — it is Y, because..."
- "This matters beyond the immediate context because at a broader level..."
- "What this ultimately suggests is that societies which... tend to..."
- "The implication of this argument is not just for this case, but for how we think about..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should governments limit AI use in hiring decisions?

"My position is that governments should require human oversight of AI-assisted hiring, not ban it outright. **The core reason is that** AI systems trained on historical data **tend to replicate** the biases embedded in that data — not because the algorithm intends to discriminate, but because past hiring patterns already reflected structural inequality. **Without mandatory oversight**, those patterns become automated and therefore harder to challenge or even identify. **What this means at a broader level is** that the question of AI in hiring is really a question about who bears the burden of proof when discrimination occurs — and historically, **that burden has fallen on individuals least equipped to carry it.**"

Bold phrases mark the PSU arc in motion — Point (position stated), Support (analytical mechanism traced), Universal (broader systemic implication reached).